14.12 Accidental Hypothermia

Assessment	Nursing Diagnosis	Plan / Expected Outcome	Nursing Interventions	Evaluation
Subjective • Found outside in the cold, drowsy **Objective** • Core temperature 31 °C • Not shivering • Speech slurred	**ACTUAL** **Hypothermia** related to prolonged exposure to cold as evidenced by core temperature 31 °C and drowsiness.	Core temperature rises by about 1–2 °C an hour, as the protocol says.	• Take off wet clothes and handle him gently. • Use active external rewarming (warm blankets, a forced-air warmer). • Give warmed IV fluids as prescribed. • Monitor core temperature continuously.	Warming safely: **goal met**.
Subjective • *No specific complaint* **Objective** • HR 42/min J waves on the ECG • BP 90/50 mmHg	**ACTUAL** **Decreased cardiac output** related to bradycardia and dysrhythmias caused by hypothermia as evidenced by slow HR and low BP.	Rhythm and BP stable as he warms up.	• Continuous ECG monitoring. • Have the defibrillator ready. • Move him gently; rough handling can set off ventricular fibrillation.	Rhythm stable: **goal met**.
Subjective • *No specific complaint* **Objective** • Being rewarmed • Fluid shifting	**RISK** **Risk for electrolyte imbalance** as evidenced by risk factors: rewarming and fluid shifts (potassium changes).	Potassium and glucose stay normal while he is rewarmed.	• Check potassium and glucose during rewarming. • Replace as ordered.	Values normal: **goal met**.